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Culture (OWC): Gikuyu (FL10)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Eastern Africa

Field Date: 1983-1984, 1992, 1994

Coverage Date: 1910-1995

Place Coverage: Mutira, Central Province, Kenya

Section Title(S): 4 Wamutira: The First Wife

Muthoni: I feel good because the banning of circumcision means that none of mine [daughters] will be destroyed that way.

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Karuana: The things nowadays are not the way they were long ago.

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Muthoni: Yes, that is so. A long time ago, if a girl matured and had her menstrual period, she would never go out. She told her mother and was shown where to stay and would stay there in the house until the days given her by God were over.

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Karuana: You would not go anywhere, nor cook or go to dances.

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Muthoni: So your clothes would all soak with menstrual blood, one after another, until the days were over.

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Wamutira: But nowadays, things are better because nobody calls another *karigū* [silly uncircumcised girl] or *kahii* [same applied to a boy], and so there are no fights between the circumcised and uncircumcised.

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Muthoni: The only fights you get nowadays are between drunkards. You can't hear a girl fighting with another girl because of *Irua*.

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Karuana: If you met an uncircumcised young man and a circumcised one you would not distinguish between them. It is only when he goes to school and is beaten by others [for not being circumcised] that he comes home and does it.

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Muthoni: Now, you can't tell the difference between one who is circumcised and one who is not. Long ago, if you were of my age group and we met and my ears were pierced, you would never joke with me or abuse me until yours were pierced, too. There was a difference between those who had been circumcised and those who had not. Now, there is no difference. The old traditions are gone.

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[Wamutira nods her head in agreement.]

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[Wamutira resumes her narrative in the next session with an account of what, for most women, seems to be the happiest period of their lives—between *Irua* and *ũhiki*, or marriage.]

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I stayed for quite a long time without thinking about marriage because of the happiness I got from dancing. Once we were circumcised, then we could go for dances. There was *mweretho*, where each man would dance with a girl and would throw her up in the air and the girl would shake her whole body. There was *gicukia*, which was attended by those not circumcised, and another by only those who were circumcised. We used to go to dance very far from home when there was moonlight.

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